

the material possessions which they believe are solid proofs rather than frail symbols of ability, achievement and success. They accept as manifest truth the shoddy theory that they can gain social position and the respect of others only by out earning and out buying those around them.

They have no interest in building anything but their own bank balances; they are not concerned with values, but only with the dollars-and-cents prices they pay for their possessions.

I've encountered more concrete examples of this distorted viewpoint than I'd care to count. Quite typical of them was my recent experience with a businessman who paid me a visit in London, arriving with a letter of introduction from a mutual acquaintance in New York.

After spending more than two hours boasting about how much money he'd made in the last few years, my visitor informed me that he was on his way to France, where he intended to buy some paintings.

"I've heard that you're quite an art collector," he said. "I thought you could help me out by giving me the names and addresses of some reliable art galleries or dealers from whom I could do my buying."

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"Are you interested in paintings from any special period or of any particular school?" I inquired. "Or are you looking for works by some particular artist?"

"It doesn't make any difference to me," the man shrugged impatiently. "I wouldn't know one from another in any case. I just have to buy some paintings—and I have to spend at least \$100,000 for them."

"Why can't you spend less than that?" I asked, puzzled that anyone would set an arbitrary minimum rather than a maximum on what he wanted to spend.

"Oh, it's one of those things," came the straight-faced explanation. "My partner was over here a couple of months ago and he paid \$75,000 for some